
THE MAN WHO WOULDN'T REPENT

Four decades on, Gowan's "A Criminal Mind" still wins the argument it was built to lose — that a man with no conscience is freer than the men who guard him.

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There is a moment near the end of "A Criminal Mind" when the song stops being a portrait and becomes a defense. The narrator — a lifer, addressing what sounds like a courtroom — turns the terms of his sentence inside out. He will die behind these walls, he grants. But he is not the one who is trapped. The guards, the judges, the decent people who need a conscience to sleep at night: they are the ones carrying the weight. He carries nothing. In his telling, the absence of remorse is not a defect. It is a kind of liberty.

It is a repugnant argument, and it is delivered so persuasively that forty years later we are still turning it over. That is the achievement of the song, and it is why it deserves a longer look than a hit single usually gets. Lawrence Gowan did not write a story about a criminal. He wrote a criminal's brief, in the first person, and then handed us the uncomfortable job of deciding whether it holds.

1

A voice, not a verdict

Gowan has been asked to explain the song more than any other he has written, and his answer has stayed consistent: the words are not his own confession but the declaration of a character he found somewhere in his own psyche. The seed was mundane and Canadian. The title came out of a conversation with the display's curator — a man newly retired after thirty-five years working at the penitentiary — and the character crystallized around a Kingston Penitentiary cell reconstructed, of all places, as an exhibit at the Canadian National Exhibition. A prison cell dropped into the fairground — the sugar-and-diesel hum of

the midway pressing against the airless chill of the reconstructed cell — is the whole song in a single image: confinement staged as spectacle, the thing we lock away put on display for the price of a ticket.

What Gowan did with it belongs to an old and difficult tradition. “A Criminal Mind” is a dramatic monologue in the strict literary sense — the form Robert Browning perfected in poems like “My Last Duchess,” where a speaker damns himself precisely by making his case so well. The power of the form is also its trap. To inhabit the voice convincingly, the writer has to grant it dignity, rhythm, even charm. The listener is drawn into complicity, then left to climb back out. Gowan understood the danger. During the song’s rise he went out of his way, in a MuchMusic spot, to draw the line most of his imitators never bothered to: a criminal *mind* may deserve understanding, but a criminal *act* is another matter entirely. The song asks for the first without excusing the second. That is a needle most pop songs never even try to thread.

2

The architecture of a confession

The reason the argument lands is that the music refuses to editorialize. “A Criminal Mind” is notated in B-flat major, but its weight falls unmistakably toward G minor — the relative minor beneath that brighter frame — and it stays there, with the same refusal as its narrator. Gowan was no accidental melodist. He earned his ARCT in classical piano from Toronto’s Royal Conservatory of Music at nineteen, and the compositional discipline shows in how the song is built to breathe.

Read the piano writing across its full span and a deliberate shape emerges. It opens quietly, close and confessional, a man talking rather than performing. It thickens by degrees. Then, across the long central stretch, it climbs to full weight and simply *stays there* — not a single climactic spike but a sustained plateau, dense and loud, held far longer than a pop arrangement usually dares. That plateau is the plea: not a cry that peaks and releases, but a wall of insistence that will not back down. And then, pointedly, the floor drops out and the intimacy returns, before the final rebuild. The music enacts the psychology. A pop song usually builds toward release — the chorus that lifts, the modulation that forgives. This one refuses. The plateau is load-bearing: a wall built to hold weight, not to open a door. A man who feels no remorse does not climb toward catharsis, because catharsis is the sound of guilt being set down, and he is not carrying any. The song does not resolve because it is not asking to be forgiven. He states his case, holds it, and states it again. The form is the character.

This is where the song separates itself from its radio neighbors. It is not verse-chorus reassurance. It is theatre — a piano-driven, minor-key monologue with the pacing of a stage soliloquy, closer to European art-rock than to anything else on Canadian AM in 1985.

3

The room where it was made

There is a reason for that European cast, and it is one of the great underexposed stories in Canadian rock. After a 1982 debut that went nowhere, Gowan retreated into Toronto's Queen Street West scene, spent a year writing, and travelled to Scotland and Ireland to trace his own roots. On that trip the producer David Tickle heard his demos and offered to make the record. What followed reads like a tall tale. Sessions were booked at Startling Studios — Ringo Starr's home studio at Tittenhurst Park, the same estate where John Lennon had recorded *Imagine*. Tickle brought in much of Peter Gabriel's touring band: bassist Tony Levin, drummer Jerry Marotta, guitarist David Rhodes.

Gowan has described arriving with the bones already sketched — the core bass and drum ideas mapped in his demos — and watching Levin and Marotta colorize his black-and-white drawings into something world-class. That lineage matters. The rhythm section that gave Gabriel's "psychological pop" its unease is the same one anchoring "A Criminal Mind," and you can hear the inheritance in the song's coiled restraint. Recorded in a Beatle's house, played by a Genesis alumnus's band, it arrived on Canadian radio sounding like a transmission from somewhere more dangerous.

4

The MuchMusic moment

Timing finished what talent started. "A Criminal Mind" reached the Canadian top five in early 1985, and it did so on the back of an image as much as a sound. MuchMusic had launched in September 1984, and the industry press of the day identified Gowan as the clearest beneficiary of the new channel — an artist whose ambitious, cinematic clips were made for the format at the exact moment the format arrived. The video, a two-month collaboration with director Rob Quartly, won the Juno Award for Best Video that year. The song itself was nominated for Single of the Year and lost to Corey Hart's "Never Surrender" — a fitting rivalry, two very different visions of the Canadian pop protagonist, the survivor and the unrepentant.

Strange Animal went double platinum. A quirky domestic hopeful became a national star, and he did it with his least commercial song leading the charge — a dark, talky, minor-key monologue about a man beyond redemption. That it worked at all is a small miracle of the MuchMusic era. That it endured is something else.

5

The long life of a criminal

Most hits of 1985 are period pieces now. "A Criminal Mind" is not, and its second act explains why. In 1999 Gowan joined the American institution Styx, replacing founding frontman Dennis DeYoung. When he balked at singing "Babe" — a song DeYoung had written for his wife, and not Gowan's to sing — the

band folded “A Criminal Mind” into the set instead. A Canadian art-pop monologue became a fixture on American arena stages, and a new audience met it cold, with no memory of 1985 to soften it.

The recognitions kept arriving. SOCAN honored the song for crossing 100,000 radio plays in Canada. In 2018 it was certified a platinum single. And in 2022 the whole *Strange Animal* project found yet another generation when Jordan Peele reached for its title track in *Nope* — proof that Gowan’s brand of anxious, literate pop still reads as strange and modern to ears that have never heard of him.

The song lasts because the argument never resolves. We know the narrator is wrong. We cannot quite say where. He has taken the vocabulary of freedom — the thing the decent people prize most — and claimed it for the one man in the room who has forfeited every reason to deserve it. Gowan hands us that inversion and declines to correct it. He trusts the listener to do the moral work the character refuses to do.

That trust is why “A Criminal Mind” is not a relic. It is a machine that still runs: a confession that admits nothing, a plea that asks for nothing, a defense that wins on points and loses on truth. Four decades on, the cell door stays shut, and the man behind it is still making his case. We are still, uneasily, listening.

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